

Habitat & Cultivation *Gymnema* is native to forests of central and southern India, Southeast Asia, and as far south as northern Australia. It prefers loamy soil.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents *Gymnema* contains saponins (gymnemic acids) and a polypeptide (gurmarin).

History & Folklore *Gymnema* has long been used in Indian domestic medicine as a remedy for sugar cravings and diabetes. Its Hindi name means "sugar destroyer."

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Gymnema* has real value in treating diabetes, especially in the early stages of type 2 diabetes, which develops in middle to old age. If taken consistently for a year or more, it will help to prevent the condition deteriorating. *Gymnema* may help to regenerate cells in the pancreas that secrete insulin, so it may be possible to control or reverse mild diabetes with diet and *gymnema*. The plant's remarkable ability to block sweet tastes means that it can reduce sugar cravings and contribute to weight-loss programs.

Research In recent research in India and Japan, *gymnema* has shown promise as a safe and effective natural treatment for diabetes. In two clinical trials in India, patients with diabetes needed less insulin or other treatments to lower blood-sugar levels. There is an indication that *gymnema* may encourage repair of the islet cells of the pancreas, responsible for insulin secretion. The leaves have been shown to anesthetize the sweet taste buds of the tongue, and temporarily reduce appetite.

Haronga madagascariensis (Guttiferae)

Haronga

Description Small evergreen tree growing to 26 ft (8 m). Has black-dotted leaves with a dark green upper surface and red-brown hairs underneath, and clusters of creamy-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation *Haronga* is native to Madagascar and East Africa, and grows in tropical areas. The leaves and bark are collected throughout the year.

Parts Used Leaves, bark.

Constituents *Haronga* bark contains phenolic pigments, triterpenes, anthraquinones, and tannins. The leaves contain phenolic pigments, the diterpene hypericin, flavonoids, and tannins. Hypericin, which is also found in St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106), has antiviral properties.

History & Folklore *Haronga* resin has traditionally been used in Africa to secure arrowheads onto shafts.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Thought to stimulate bile secretion, *haronga* is used in European herbal medicine to treat indigestion and poor pancreatic function. In African herbal medicine, *haronga* is chiefly employed as an astringent and mild laxative, and is also given for digestive system ailments such as diarrhea and dysentery.

Hedera helix (Araliaceae)

Ivy, English Ivy

Description A woody climber up to 100 ft (30 m) with leathery, dark green leaves, clusters of greenish-yellow flowers and black or orange berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and northern and central Asia, ivy has been introduced, often as a garden climber, in many parts of the world. In the wild, it typically grows on trees and in hedges.

Parts Used Leaves, berries.

Constituents Ivy contains saponins, sterols, polyacetylenes, a volatile oil, and flavonoids.

The saponins are expectorant, amebicidal, and antifungal, and kill liver flukes.

History & Folklore In the classical world, common ivy was dedicated to Dionysus, the god of wine making and intoxication. Ivy was thought to be able to prevent or undo drunkenness. The leaf was traditionally used in England to treat corns and warts—it was soaked in vinegar and bound on as a poultice, or placed inside a sock, overlying the corn.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Ivy is chiefly used for congestion of the ear, nose, and throat, as well as for bronchitis. It acts as



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an expectorant, stimulating the coughing up and clearance of phlegm. It has a beneficial effect on mucous membranes and is generally combined with tonic herbs, especially thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143). Ivy extracts are common ingredients in cosmetic formulations for cellulite.

Caution Fresh leaves can irritate the skin.

Herniaria glabra (Caryophyllaceae) Rupturewort

Description Prostrate annual or perennial with bright green oval leaves and clusters of green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Rupturewort is found throughout Europe and western Asia. It thrives in barren areas, in lime and sandy soils. It is gathered when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Rupturewort contains coumarins (including 3% herniarin and scopoletin), flavonoids, phenolic acids, and saponins.

History & Folklore Rupturewort was first documented in European herbals of the 16th century. Its genus name, *Herniaria*, refers to its reputed ability to heal hernias.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Rupturewort is of value chiefly as a diuretic herb. The fresh plant treats urinary problems such as cystitis, irritable bladder, and kidney stones. It is also astringent, and has been applied as a poultice to speed the healing of ulcers. The whole plant appears to have an antispasmodic effect on the bladder.

Hibiscus sabdariffa (Malvaceae) Hibiscus, Jamaica

Description Shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m) in height.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North Africa and Southeast Asia, hibiscus grows in tropical regions around the world. It is primarily cultivated across Africa and in Thailand, China, and Mexico.

Parts Used Calyx (the outer base of the flower), flowers, leaves.

Constituents The calyx and flowers contain flavonoids, including anthocyanins.

History & Folklore "Hibiscus" means "plant that is consecrated to the ibis," a bird held sacred in ancient Egypt.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Hibiscus makes a refreshing, pleasant-tasting tea that is cooling and mildly sedative, soothing hot and feverish